security to protect him from arrest. But Shekhawat clarified that the cover was for his role as Punjab's party in-charge.

In the past two months or so, Gehlot has renewed his interest in the Sanjeevani case. So far, three chargesheets have been filed, and investigations have reportedly been vetted by government lawyers. Late last month, the CM said that investors, many of them Rajputs, had been approaching him—in a bid to alienate the prominent Rajput leader of the Marwar region from his community vote bank.

In December last year, a cylinder blast during a wedding, which led to the death of 35 people, mostly Rajputs, had given Gehlot a stick to beat Shekhawat with. The latter's opponents insisted that the community had found him wanting in providing immediate relief. Shekhawat said, "Gehlot is vindictive because I defeated his son Vaibhav in the 2019 election in Jodhpur." This certainly ignited the personal rivalry between them, but what really made Shekhawat Gehlot's 'target' was his alleged involvement in toppling his government during the infamous 2020 revolt by the then deputy CM and state Congress president Sachin Pilot. The case has, however, seen little headway, with a local court last month refusing the Anti-Corruption Bureau's request for Shekhawat's voice samples.

There is another contentious issue between the two leaders—the Eastern River Canal Project. Shekhawat snubbed minister Mahesh Joshi and accused him of lying when the latter urged the former to remind the PM of his promise to implement the irrigation project last April. Gehlot took exception to how Shekhawat treated his minister and has since used the central negligence of the project as an election issue—and to his advantage. That BJP-ruled Madhya Pradesh moved the Supreme Court to halt the project accusing Rajasthan of trying to block the flow of water in excess of what is permitted, is helping Gehlot. Shekhawat has to be seen doing enough to bring the project on ground. The Union minister may have placed himself in a position to take on Gehlot but should avoid falling into his trap and risking his CM prospects. ■

MADHYA PRADESH

INDIA'S NEW SP

By Rahul Noronha

For a little over a week, ace rifle and pistol shooters from across the globe along with the sport's top administrators will congregate in Bhopal for the ISSF World Cup that kicks off on March 20. The prestigious International Shooting Sport Federation (ISSF) tournament will be among a series of national and international sports events that Madhya Pradesh has hosted over the past two years.

Be it the pistol shooting, equestrian and women's boxing nationals towards the end of 2022, or the women's ITF (International Tennis Federation) tournament in January and the Khelo India Youth Games—that saw nearly 6,000 young athletes from across the country take part in 27 disciplines—in February, capital Bhopal has been buzzing with sports activities. Then, there were the national canoe sprint championship (March 2022), men's hockey national meet (April) and junior athletics nationals (September) among the events on the city's sports calendar last year.

Backed by government funds and state-of-the-art facilities, Madhya Pradesh—and Bhopal in particular—is fast turning into India's sports hub. Several sports academies and stadiums have come up here in the past decade. Besides nurturing budding athletes, they have given the state a platform to host national and international events.

Inaugurating the Youth Games at Bhopal's Tatya Tope Stadium on January 30, Chief Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan had promised that "there will be no shortage of funds to promote the state's sporting talent" while announcing Rs 5 lakh for each medal winner from MP. In the 2023-24 state budget unveiled on March 1, the allocation for sports stood at Rs 738 crore, over three times the Rs 235 crore allocated last year. (Though the sports budget for 2022-23 was later bumped up to Rs 476 crore to hold the big-ticket Youth Games.)

"We saw Bhopal's shooting



AIMING HIGH
The rifle shooting nationals underway in Bhopal, Nov. 2021



"SPORTS ACADEMIES LOCATED IN BIG CITIES WILL BE CONNECTED TO FEEDER CENTRES IN DISTRICTS TO IDENTIFY AND NURTURE TALENT AT GRASSROOTS LEVEL"

YASHODHARA RAJE
Sports Minister, MP